Elasticsearch parses a string value and infers that it is a date if the value conforms to the ISO 8601 date standard. That is, the date value is expected to be in the format `yyyy-MM-dd` or (with a time component) `yyyy-MM-ddTHH:mm:ss`.

JSON doesn't have a date type, so dates in incoming documents are expressed as strings. These are parsed by Elasticsearch and indexed appropriately. For example, a value such as

```
"article_date":"2021-05-01" or "article_date":"2021-05-01T15:45:50"
```

is considered a date and is indexed as a date type because the value conforms to the ISO standard.

As we did with other data types, we can create a field with the `date` type during the mapping definition. The next listing creates a `departure_date_time` field for a flight document.

Listing 4.17 Creating an index with a `date` type

```
PUT flights
{
  "mappings": {
    "properties": {
      "departure_date_time":{
        "type": "date"
      }
    }
  }
}
```

When indexing a flight document, setting `"departure_date_time" :"2021-08-06"` (or `"2021-08-06T05:30:00"` with a time component) will index the document with the date as expected.

> **NOTE** When no mapping definition for a date field exists in an index, Elasticsearch parses a document successfully when the date format is either `yyyy-MM-dd` (ISO date format) or `yyyy/MM/dd` (non-ISO date format). However, once we've created the mapping definition for a date, the date format of the incoming document is expected based on the format defined in the mapping definition.

We can change the format of the date if we need to: instead of setting the date in ISO format (`yyyy-MM-dd`), we can customize the format based on our needs by setting it on the field during field creation:

```
PUT flights
{
  "mappings": {
    "properties": {
      "departure_date_time":{
        "type": "date",
```